CORHC-0002 — Clark Welch & Ray Albin Oral History — August 10, 2007

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:01
Okay. My name is Carrie Tarasuk. I'm the Assistant Curator of Collections at the First Division Museum at Cantigny. We're here at the First Division Reunion in St. Louis, Missouri. on Friday, August 10th, 2007.

Clark Welch
00:14
And we're doing an oral history with I'm Clark Welch. Okay.

Ray Albin
00:21
And I'm Ray Albin. Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:23
Okay, um my first question for both of you is the Battle of Ang Tan was part of Operation Shenandoah. And I know that there was Shenandoah 1 and 2. Can you explain that a little better, what the purpose of Operation Shenandoah was and just give me a better understanding of that?

Clark Welch
00:43
My my answer is not gonna be very good. I didn't have any idea what operation we were on or what it was called.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:50
Okay.

Clark Welch
00:50
I didn't even know it was the Battle of Ong Tom until after it was over. And I really didn't know until I read in newspapers that it was part of Shenandoah. I'm sure that there was a good purpose for it, but I had no idea what operation we were on.

Ray Albin
01:04
And conversely, usually the information got down through command level to the enlisted men. And somehow, because I recall a letter I wrote, to a girl and uh it indicated that we were on

operation Shenandoah II. I actually gave her the grid coordinates of where we were.

01:23
at On Tan and said that if she had a map she could find it. It's in the book by David. And uh I knew it was Shenandoah too, but even after the battle I remember uh a chaplain referring to it in the service back at Lycay as the Battle of the 17th.

01:40
I think I indicated that to you yesterday. And only with David Marinus's or Moranus's book Did I learn that it was called the Battle of Long Tan? When that name came on board, I I don't know.

01:53
But I did know we were on Operation Shenandoah too, but I didn't have any other particulars as to who the enemy was and

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:02
So you just knew it was referred to as Apparation Shenandoah and didn't remember anything else about it.

Ray Albin
02:13
you know as difficult as we assumed probably and more so. Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:18
Um I wanted to ask what do you think of um Terry Allen Jr. and How do you how do you think how how do you think he felt about the plan for that day? From the reading that I've done, you know, it sounded like he was following orders and maybe not saying much about it, but how do you think he personally felt

Clark Welch
02:42
Again, my answer is uh he was my battalion commander and uh a good army guy, no matter what level you do what your boss says So my uh every thought about Terry Allen, I didn't know his first name. I knew he was Colonel Allen. I did not know he was famous.

03:01
I didn't know his father was famous. I didn't, you know, y you guys weren't there with your books I didn't know that he had three daughters. I knew that he had some kind of problem, but hell everybody had problems.

03:14
What I knew of him was that he was a a good, fine gentleman. Uh had no business being out there in the middle of a war in the middle of a jungle, but a good, honest, fine gentleman. And it

was uh very confusing for me when I would hear him say things that didn't make sense, because I you expect a good fine man, but I didn't know anything about him being uh important being famous.

03:45
Uh and I really didn't have a very good feeling for any pressure he was under. He didn't, no I I say he didn't. I was present when he briefed the generals, although I think just one general was there and some colonels to include Major Hollander and some colonels on the evening of the 16th. And I I didn't see any, when I was present, I didn't see any pressure.

04:14
I saw the colonel, my boss, talking about what a wonderful job we'd done the 16th, and we had done good the 16th. And uh the colonel saying, yep, we'll go back in and get them tomorrow. A good idea.

04:26
Uh I didn't, but I I wasn't privy to what the gentleman, the colonel, had to say. I was not aware of any pressure on him until while the battle was going on. It was obvious to me that He was on the phone, but the person on the other end of the phone wasn't listening.

04:45
Not a very good answer yet.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:48
Honest one.

Ray Albin
04:51
And as a sergeant in the border platoon at that time, I had absolutely no contact with Colonel Allen. I knew just through my chain of command and the fact that I had to know that Colonel Allen was the battalion commander. I didn't have any inkling of you know, his being related to Terry Allen Senior or that he had any kind of problems.

05:11
Uh he was my battalion commander and uh I knew less about him than Colonel Welch did. Okay. And that's just the way you know it was.

05:20
I mean, enlisted men did not know that much about that.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
05:26
Right.

Clark Welch
05:28
Jim Shelton would be the only man that I know of that would know what Colonel Allen was like. Jim Shelton was Colonel Allen's friend, only friend. No, I don't want to say only friend.

05:42
No, no, but he was a good friend. Intimate that yeah. And Jim Shelton knew exactly what he's doing, what he's thinking.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
05:53
I was I was hoping we have um we already have an oral history with you um recounting some of the you know the events of the battle but I thought it would be very interesting and very helpful if both of you could could recount kind of what happened on the 17th together

Clark Welch
06:16
It'll be from different perspectives because absolutely, but it should be good. It should it should match.

Ray Albin
06:23
It should different perspectives, however, because I was not at the ambush site, I was in the weapons or mortar platoon and then made it to the I'm gonna call it an ambush. I don't care. Ambush site. Good words.

Clark Welch
06:35
It was an attack on a fortified position. Yes. We just didn't know that.

Ray Albin
06:38
So my mine would be a completely different perspective up until the point where I made it with I don't know what you want to call it rescue people or whatever. I don't know what we were rescuing, but rescue people there. And so You know, Colonel Welch obviously has more the preponderance of the information.

Clark Welch
06:57
Everybody that was in my uh morta plutone. were smart people. We were all infantrymen, so we're whatever we were.

07:04
I mean, we're just guys out there in the middle of the woods. But from the platoon leader, Fred Mager, who died just recently. On down to the lowest uh uh private uh I don't I don't uh they

were smart guys that was selected for that, that they had to do math, they had to do figuring.

07:21
We didn't have to do figuring. And uh Long story, of course, but to make it short, on the 16th, my mortar, my, I'm not bragging, I'm saying my I love my mortar platoon did Almost textbook perfect. All the way out on the 16th, they fired to the left, they fired to the right because mortars Are good mortars sometimes fire too short or too long, but mortars very seldom fire wrong to the left or far wrong to the right.

07:50
So while we walked out The mortars fired to our left and right, the artillery fired to our front. It was almost like an exercise. And anything I'm not sure who I talked to when I called back.

08:01
Uh sometimes I called back, sometimes my sergeants would call back, but the uh Everything uh on the 16th, nothing's perfect, but it was perfect. Uh no screaming voices when when you talk back to uh you know fire alpha three, fire alpha seven, uh you just get Roger on the way. On the 16th, it was almost perfect.

Ray Albin
08:22
I wonder if I could just interrupt for a second. Sorry. But we were if we were almost perfect, it was because we had trained that way.

08:30
prior to going into showing. trust their mortars. Okay.

08:44
But that was no accident that we were prepared on the 16th because we had prepared ourselves or had a we Clark or Lieutenant Welch or Colonel Welch had prepared us.

Clark Welch
08:52
We worked hard on uh I was very fortunate. I was given a couple weeks to train together before we had to go out and fight. The division did have a lot of rules because mortars are Mortars are dangerous.

09:05
If a mortar went off in this room, it'd kill all of us. Mortars are dangerous. So the division did have a lot of rules.

09:12
Have to be this close, have to be this far away, have to do this. And we worked hard at uh making sure you obey the r you can't disobey the rules, but as an example, you can't shoot

until admission is approved. So when I woke up in the morning, 4 o'clock, 5 o'clock, whatever it was, I was call the mortars and I would say, I got a mission for you.

09:35
Fire one round right out there. And boom, that's that's the mission. Now the mission is approved.

09:42
Sometimes it would take, I'd I'd wake up at four, uh five, wake up at five, I would call the artillery and I'd call it easy to call the motors, they're just laying right over there. And I would say, I've got a new mission for you, fire. And we get, then they have to get all these approvals.

09:56
You have to get approvals to mortar shoots high, you have to make sure no airplanes are around. Just bullshit. So sometimes it take two or three minutes, sometimes it take two hours to get approval.

10:07
But the point was, by the time it came time to do any fighting, We already had approval. The mortars had started that mission. They'd f fired one round and then maybe go the whole day without firing again.

10:19
And and the the distances, you know, you you have to know where everybody is. I had designated smoke because the people up in the helicopter I knew where everybody was. They knew where everybody was.

10:30
They wouldn't have shot on me. But the people who'd fly over in the helicopters would say, Where are you? So I had des one man on each platoon that was called a smoke man.

10:39
And if the general expected me to be over by that road junction, but I wasn't over there because you go to road junk and you get killed, and the general would fly over said and said, How come you're not at the road junction? Oh sir, I am. And then he will say, well smoke, throw smoke.

10:56
I want to know where you are. So I would designate First Platoon. Run out to that road junction and throw smoke because some fruitcake up there wants us to be at the road junction.

11:06
So the the guy would leave all his equipment behind, pick up a can of smoke and run out there and throw the thing and come running back in and hope nobody shot him. So we we you follow

the rules, but the uh these guys, they were good. We'd had a couple of accidents back in uh their first platoon sergeant W some of the first rounds we ever fired back at our base camp when we were shooting, we were living, it's in a tent with a dirt floor, but it's a place to live.

11:34
In the mortars were out there we cut down thousands of dollars worth of rubber trees to give these guys a place to fire. It paid back the vehicle. Somebody had to pay.

11:42
I don't I don't know. But so man, they raised hell when they came in there. We we'd cut down all these rubber trees.

11:49
So these are guys have a place to shoot, and then we use the rubber trees and cut them into ten foot-long places and they were the overhead cover for the bunkers. I thought it was really good Some guy came down there store a check and I think we owed him $400,000 or something.

Ray Albin
12:01
I don't care. This was back in Lycate.

Clark Welch
12:04
But we would shoot at night. We'd shoot. We're we're defending this position, not defending, because the enemy's out there. We shoot over their heads. But one night it w a round and I heard when it fired, it w you know mortar rounds are supposed to go whoop and this one went boop.

Ray Albin
12:19
Yep

Clark Welch
12:20
And I came running down there and what had happened was the uh because of a defect in the factory, the tail had come off the mortar round. So when the mortar round came out, it didn't have a tail on it that stayed a tube or something. Right or or whatever it did.

12:34
So the mortar round came out and tumbled, so it didn't go way out there. It went back here and it landed close to one of our own guys and wounded somebody, I think. So as I came running out to the p uh mortars to see what had happened, the first sergeant went out to the man that had been hurt, and literally my first sergeant, who uh my beloved first sergeant, kept the man

alive.

12:56
So he didn't die, but he was hurt. And when I came back to the mortar platoon, the platoon sergeant back there had a compass because he knew that he'd done everything right and he's going to walk out there into enemy territory. to find out what went wrong with it.

13:10
He guessed that the tail came off. But if the tail came off, he said, sir, I'll find it. I'll find the goddamn thing.

13:15
It wasn't our fault. It wasn't our fault. And it wasn't him trying to get out of Yeah.

13:20
You know, not what it was him just they were awfully good. They were awfully good. Now When I came back in on the 16th, I went to the mortar platoon first to talk to them.

13:34
I don't know if I shook their hand, but we probably drank a cup of coffee. The mortars were Wonderful, wonderful, wonderful. And the mortars would often come out with us.

13:44
Uh I would usually take one or two sergeants from the mortar platoon who would walk with us, because that way they could talk back and the guys Like to get a chance to come out with us is kind of exciting out there. And the most of the guys who were mortarmen had walked with us. Uh it wasn't that you were in the mortars, so therefore you stayed back in the Most of them, so I knew they were very, very good now in the 17th.

14:12
When I was told that I would not be the lead company And the lead company, it's always good to be up front. You know, you don't want to be picking up somebody else's crap. When I was told I wouldn't be the lead company, the most important thing was that I wouldn't get to fire the artillery.

14:29
I wouldn't get to fire the mortars. That's a good rule. You get two people moving through the woods.

14:34
If this guy starts firing, he's liable to shoot up the guy in front. So the rule is only the guy in front can fire. Fine.

14:42
Now the same way that this other stuff, I went ahead and I sat down with the mortars and I sat,

well you call artillery on the telephone. With my forward observer. And we made plans for the 17th, just like the 16th.

15:00
On the way out, Alpha 1, Alpha 2, Alpha 3, Alpha 4, Alpha 5, those are the targets. Bravo 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. What if I get hit here?

15:09
So we'll set up a Delta 127. What if I get hit here? What if we want the enemy to think we're going that direction, so we'll fire some mortars off that way So the enemy will think we're going in that direction.

15:20
I made all of those plans, knowing that we weren't going to be allowed to fire. But we made all the plans. And when we walked out, and we started to walk at 8 o'clock in the morning and from 8 till 10 o'clock, when we walked, I was constantly talking to these guys, saying, I know we can't fire because we're not the guys up front.

15:40
However If we could, you'd now fire Alpha 1. And no one fired between 8 and 10. Nobody because the lead company, because we were sneaking up on them, no one fired.

15:54
The artillery didn't fire. The Air Force, I think, fired, but it was ten miles away or something. You don't hear it.

16:00
You can't only hear about a quarter mile in the jungle. No artillery, no nothing, just absolute quiet. But I kept talking to uh it wouldn't have been Lieutenant Baker because he would have been busy.

16:10
It would have been somebody was his kilo or the platoon sergeant.

Ray Albin
16:19
Yeah, I was in the FDC.

Clark Welch
16:27
So that was in a gunhole and if it rained it rained on him.

Ray Albin
16:31
Yeah, and there was constant radio chatter, radio traffic with the with the elements of our

company. We didn't have any contact. with Alpha Company because we're not Alpha Company, but we had constant contact with Delta and there was no fire mission, but we had to be ready because you know we everybody was in the gun holes everybody.

Clark Welch
16:49
I assume that they're moving the guns to keep up with each thing I called.

Ray Albin
16:52
And setting deflections as you marched.

Clark Welch
16:54
Yeah. Everything uh Our conversation between 8 and 10, I would call back and say, don't fire, of course. We're still on it, we're not allowed to fire, but lay on Alpha 1. And calm, yes sir. And I just knew this is good.

Ray Albin
17:09
Yeah.

Clark Welch
17:11
I know they're back there just like that. And if I say fire, they'll fire and Uh eight seconds later, twenty seconds later, depending on how high it goes, I'm gonna get around, land right there. It was from eight to ten constant contact with the uh mortars, constant contact with the uh artillery, but always don't shoot, don't shoot.

17:32
Now, at ten o'clock, or by at ten o'clock I I I called back to the mortars and I said, hey, fire Alpha 7 and Bravo 7, because uh this is bad news. I don't care, you know, fire. I don't that we're not sneaking up on them anymore.

17:50
There's a I didn't know there's a thousand of them out there, but I knew there was a lot of them out there.

Ray Albin
17:54
And this was subsequent to Alpha's Contact?

Clark Welch
17:57
Yes, about the same, almost instantly with Alpha's Contact. And the mortars, uh mortars

belonged to me I certainly thought that I would call back and say, hey, I don't give a shit about the rules, fire Alpha 7, fire Bravo 7. And I did something like that.

18:14

No excitement yet, just, okay, all bets are off. Fire Alpha 7, Fire Bravo 7. And nothing happened.

18:21

And I yelled at the uh Lieutenant Durham, get the artillery. Now, between the time of the first round and the time that Alpha Company became non-combat effective. Not because of any I mean the Army doctrine says if you're ambushed by a group of people that outnumber you, you run away.

18:42

So Alpha the Company didn't do anything wrong. Alpha Company do what you're told to do. But by two minutes, five minutes past ten, Alpha Company was gone.

18:54

So there was nobody in Alpha Company to call for mortar fire. Alpha Company never fired their mortars because nobody could call for them No artillery ever fired in support of Alpha Company because the Forward Observer was hit and killed, I think, in the first burst. So I left it up to Lieutenant Durham to talk to the artillerymen to I don't care.

19:14

You know, d what do you have to have a secret code word? I didn't say that, but the you know, tell him to shoot for us. And the resolution of the artilleries, which is different from he and I. Resident Lucian Turnbury was by about 15 or 20 minutes.

19:27

My Lieutenant Durham had been able to, I think you know the exact times, but about 15 minutes. My Lieutenant Durham, who I'm screaming at right here is in contact with a captain, somebody in the artillery, who had said, I've got orders not to fire for you, but I'm gonna fire anyway. And I think we know who those people are and I think he doesn't want to talk about it.

19:48

But and artillery captain back there. So now we had artillery firing to our front, but pretty far to our front because Alpha Company is in between us and it was a so now the artillery is pretty well under control. And Pinky's doing it.

20:04

Now, I still don't d no mortars are firing. And again, I I'm not mad at them because they're they're, you know, I I didn't uh uh I knew that nobody back there just said well they're confused It's just what in the hell is wrong? And nobody told me what was wrong.

20:21

And nobody told me what was wrong. It's just fire, fire, for Christ's sake, fire. And no fire, no fire.

20:29
And then I believe Lieutenant Baker came on because he had a special call sign there. I think Lieutenant Bager himself. Yeah.

20:38
came on and said I was uh what was I Dauntless Delta Six. He would just call me six. Six this is uh

Ray Albin
20:46
4-6.

Clark Welch
20:48
And I knew it was him. And I said, what the hell's wrong? What the hell's wrong?

20:53
And he said, they're not letting me fire. The major's down here with a pistol. This is what he said.

20:58
The major's down here with a pistol, he's not letting me fire. Now, I I I just, you know, b pe we had a lot of dead people. We had within minutes we had so many dead people that we couldn't you don't leave anybody there.

21:13
So if everybody that's alive picks up one dead one, and that's hard to do, usually it takes two people to carry a dead one. So within minutes, there was no, it's too late to run away. So it's just uh, Jesus Christ, fire And then when he said that, that there's a major here with a pistol, that was incom I mean, that's incomprehensible.

21:33
I mean what my mortars worked yesterday, talked to you guys this morning, been talking to you for two hours I didn't say all that, I just said, fire for Christ's sake, fire. And then after two or three calls of me calling him, And saying, fire. At this time, fire anything, you know, just any way a shot would have killed him.

21:56
Just fire. And and uh then Maeger is off, now I'm talking to somebody else, and it's just we can't, sir, we can't. And finally, I don't know how long it was, 20, 30 minutes. I just didn't call for them.

22:12
Well, my radio gets shot. If we found a good radio, we gave it to Lieutenant Durham. So it wasn't too long and I didn't have any radio.

22:21
But didn't make it my battalion commander was right there, I could talk to him. My three platoon leaders were right there, I could talk to them. These guys I don't think I believed that I couldn't comprehend what was going on as that'll lead up, he'll tell you.

22:37
I couldn't comprehend what was going on back there. I had called back correctly. I'd talked to the person correctly.

22:44
I was calm at the beginning. I got kind of screwed up later on. And and they weren't shooting.

22:50
So when it came time, the a radio would get knocked out. Okay, I gotta give up, you know, the the the artillery man would lose his radio. You gotta keep so you bring a radio up to him And then you're coming back and some other guys, radio operators were getting hit and killed.

23:06
At some point, probably 10. 30, I no longer even tried to call the mortars. Just this is I don't know why.

23:16
And then I vaguely remember But I remember guys from Recon Platoon. He was right, I don't know. I remember guys from Recon Platoon coming in very late in the day.

23:29
It wasn't, you know, the battle started at 10, on the on the drop of ten. The enemy commander said that. I saw it on my watch.

23:36
The enemy the firing started at ten, two plus two or three seconds The firing ended at twelve according to the enemy commander. All I know my watch was blow blown off, so I don't know what time it was. After half hour I stopped calling them.

23:53
After half hour I wasn't, I just, they're not shooting. Certainly be nice if they were shooting. And then I was unconscious and evacuated, so I never knew, never knew, and then he'll fill in, but and until I met Lieutenant Bager Between

Ray Albin
24:17

Probably at Reno.

Clark Welch
24:18
At Reno four or six years ago. Yeah. And he came up to me and and I I thought I recognized him, but I don't want to make a mistake with these guys.

24:27
And he said, Sir, I'm Lieutenant Maker. And he started to cry. He said, I'm so sorry.

24:33
I'm so sorry. That I that I didn't shoot. And he was sobbing.

24:38
I was sobbing. I'm not making fun of anybody. This is what, 35 years later And he has spent a pretty goddamn difficult 35 years.

24:48
When I knew him, smart, bright, Probably a college graduate because the college graduate went in the recon went in scout platoon went in the mortar platoon because they knew how to do figures. Smart, bright, good kid. And then he had, from his words to me at Reno, he had had not a good life.

25:08
And then he died

Ray Albin
25:11
He was died in June of 06, he was murdered.

Clark Welch
25:14
Yeah.

Ray Albin
25:14
That's another story.

Clark Welch
25:16
So I just had this from the time I called him and said fire alpha 7 and Bravo 7. And the answer was uh uh the major's got a gun. He says we can't shoot.

Ray Albin
25:30
And it's not like that we weren't ready. I mean we had there's there's a there's a multi-step

process. In addition to getting permission, you have to have rounds broken down. Charges need to be ready to be pulled off. Charges are what allow the projectile to go further or you know closer. And the the deflections and elevations were set on guns because we were following uh Lieutenant or Colonel Welch's uh you know path of march at that time And so we were ready and it just couldn't.

Clark Welch
25:57
And it should have just been like the sixteenth. Yeah, it it should have been.

Ray Albin
26:00
It it would have been it I mean and you can't ever predict results. You know, the would the results have been the same as the sixteenth? I don't know.

26:06
We had many more targets On the 17th, that's for sure. But we just they were they weren't we weren't allowed to fire and guys were very frustrated. Um I don't remember Lieutenant Mager talking to me about his frustration, but you know, I was busy doing other things.

26:20
I remember getting out of the gun hole after the shooting started and and the shooting starts w and you can hear it in the distance and it's like it it's like all firefight start it's an occasional but but you know and all of a sudden it it reaches a crescendo at the crescendo time then the um there was an RTO on the phone, I don't know who it was, and he was calling for information or something, and everything starts to to to kind kind of focus at one point. You know, there's all kinds of chaos and and you know triple the chaos for for those out there and we're waiting you know for the call we're waiting to be able to shoot and I didn't know why and I'm the guy that had to know why you know and I didn't know why And I think Megger was maybe maybe busy, I'm just guessing, trying to get that permission. But I think the permission was, even if he got it from the major, I think the major was being directed and And and Colonel Welsh will tell me if I'm wrong.

27:11
Maybe we would be indirected from a higher level, perhaps.

Clark Welch
27:14
I don't know why. All I know is I said shoot and he didn't shoot.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
27:19
So you still don't know why?

Ray Albin

27:20

Well, but I recall a passage in in in David's book. We can read the book now. Something like division was afraid of of errors being made by mortars with people maneuvering in the jungle.

27:35

And I'll tell you, after a while, after the battle has had continued for a while, I mean Those guys had nothing to lose if we dropped a few rounds on them by mistake. Exactly. Because they were in among our wounded, you know, and they were in among everybody.

27:50

And so At that point, there was nothing to lose. You know, people were displacing everywhere. You know, so and and you know, that's I mean that's my most that was my foremost worry is beating the FTC in words was was killing my own guys, you know.

28:03

You didn't shoot at all, Led. No, no, but what I'm saying, that was a I was always a worry, but if we'd if if we Because division according to the book division was saying that you know that's that's why we're hesitant, you know, but what if you have to lose? I mean and and then we'd already done so well on this sixteenth, you know.

Clark Welch

28:18

So it was showed When I got up in the hospital later, that was one of my many questions. And and uh that I think I've told you that the circumstances of my recovery in the hospital where I was so enraged, I couldn't even find out who'd been dead, who'd been alive. I vaguely remember it's you know, you you see some guy get hit in the chest eight times.

28:44

Okay, he's dead, I should write to his mother, but maybe he's not dead, maybe it's somebody else, and I didn't have the mother's address as it didn't have anything I did have a question about wonder why the, it wasn't like that. Wonder why the mortars didn't fire. My beautiful mortars.

28:57

It didn't, not a word. And after that first, you talk about it in your book, Frillow, after that initial month or two of unbelief that this cannot have happened. The question of, you know, the question of who's dead, who's alive, that's important.

29:16

The question of, gee, how come the motors didn't fire? That kind of fell down the bottom. And I did not think anything about, I wouldn't say that, I thought about it every day, but I never uh, I wouldn't have called uh Sergeant Alban up and said uh Hey, you're my brother 17th, how come you didn't shoot?

29:33
We we wouldn't have uh he probably wouldn't want to call I don't want to say for him, but he would have wouldn't want to call me because it's embarrassing. Hey Lieutenant, how come you didn't ask for fire? What's the matter with you

Ray Albin
29:43
With all due respect, I didn't even know you were alive.

Clark Welch
29:45
Yeah, well I didn't know it was you know yeah it was just uh uh so that for that two months that you talk about, it's just God almighty, mortars didn't fire yet, but man, there's a bunch of other stuff And then the way I survived, everybody picked a way to survive, was after that two months of not being able to accomplish anything, and I had another bad month, and I just figured, man, it didn't happen. Didn't happen. And it wasn't until General Cavasso went to the war col uh Colonel Cavasso in command of the first E18th, yes.

30:17
Super commander. And I I worked from a couple of times later on. He's a retired four-star now.

30:22
Colonel Cavasso went to the War College, and when he was there, he worked on a project I think called HERO, H-E-R-O, and that acronym means something, humanity in battle or some crap. And what he was studying was defeats. And you list what what do you learn from a defeat?

30:40
Because normally we don't read much about defeats, as we know. And he called me one time and said, would you be willing to talk to me for Project Hero? And then he flew to wherever I was, not where I was, Florida Ranger Camp, I think.

30:55
and had a questionnaire and in that questionnaire was uh how was your mortar fire? And I remember sitting there with him in an old barracks at uh probably three years later, four years later, at uh the Florida Ranger Camp, Egland Air Force Base. As he was going down through the list, it was just terrible question after terrible question.

31:16
Like uh, you know, where was he? And my answers are this one. So we didn't do that.

31:22
We didn't do this. Nobody did this. I didn't hear any airplanes.

31:25

I didn't hear any helicopters. And then we came to that question about, and how is your mortar fire? I just lost it.

31:32
I said there was no mortar fire. And okay, so I thought about mortars for two minutes, three years later. And then 35 years later I see at some other reunions we didn't have any reunions for 30 years?

Ray Albin
31:50
Yeah, because there was no contact basically.

Clark Welch
31:51
No contact. No, we would have avoided. Yeah.

31:54
Like the same thing. I w I would have been afraid that he would have said, well, you dumb shit, why didn't you call for fire? I never would have said that.

32:04
And uh I was afraid that they'd Anyway, and then when we started to get back together, the first guys I met, you had three or four, really, one they were from Ohio. Yeah, I forget where the names were. But I had a chance sitting there where our wives are with us, which have a calming effect on everything.

32:22
We're sitting there and I just casually mentioned after we've been talking about he's gone back to his farm in Ohio, I don't remember his name. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Sorry.

32:32
Uh and we and we kind of you know, why didn't you shoot? Why didn't you call for fire? And then it's just again just you break Sir, uh I I think his answer is he didn't know why they shot.

32:47
But they couldn't get approval to shoot. Couldn't get approval to shoot.

Ray Albin
32:50
We were on the low end of the food chain.

Clark Welch
32:52
Was he? Yeah, we were. I mean I was.

32:56

Yeah, we were just the guys. I could tell you what I've read about why it happened, but I don't want to tell you that because there's 40 different things. What I know is I call I call my beautiful, I mean my uh Hadn't had them very long.

33:16
But whenever I called, they shot. They were mine. It was just like you can shoot a pistol from here to there.

33:20
You can shoot the mortars two, three miles. They were mine. Just unbelievable.

33:27
That uh they didn't shoot when I asked them to. It wasn't that I ordered them to. That's not how you do it.

33:32
You just say, hey, fire E37. And uh It was equ it was frustrating for, I mean obviously more frustrating for

Ray Albin
33:39
Lieutenant Welch, Colonel Welch, than it was for us, but we were extremely frustrated. And the frustration frustration carried over you know, subsequent to the battle and that I don't recall anybody talking about it anymore. You know, why there weren't there there weren't that many guys left to come up and ask us how come you guys didn't fire.

33:58
And the only response we could have given them is because we didn't we weren't allowed to fire, you know. And but nobody did that. You know, I think that everybody just wanted to put it out of their mind.

Clark Welch
34:06
And they only asked me that one time when General Cabasso asked.

Ray Albin
34:09
Yeah And uh in a in a subsequent in uh uh subsequent to the on the on the eighteenth, uh uh Captain Grosso, later our company commander, did one-to-one interviews in the in the mess hall in a secluded area somewhat like this and that question never came up of me. I mean he did it with all the people. There's like maybe thirty guys left in the company.

34:29
Most of those guys were border guys. And he asked you know he did he asked All kinds of questions, but that one I don't believe ever came up. And if it did, it's in the transcript

somewhere, but I don't recall him saying, how come the borders didn't fire.

Clark Welch
34:42
And now Major is dead.

Ray Albin
34:45
Yeah. Yeah.

Clark Welch
34:45
But then the answer comes out later, you know, apparently that we think we know 'cause we or I think I know because I read it.

Ray Albin
34:52
Yeah.

Clark Welch
34:52
And it certainly matches everything else that was going on that day.

Ray Albin
34:55
Yeah.

Clark Welch
34:56
They fired the 16th, fired really good. The fact that you fired all the way out and then they fired us all the way back. Mortars are wonderful

Ray Albin
35:07
Mortars In the hands of the right people.

Clark Welch
35:11
They were good. They were very good. They were very good and they're very proud. I don't know if they'd been a mortar platoon before even. I think we might have just drawn, you know, count off by fours and everybody's a four year on the mortar platoon.

Ray Albin
35:20
I fortunately had mortar training. Yeah, well, yeah. There was other guys there that had more training. Some some were just put in there because they needed bodies, you know.

Clark Welch
35:31
But they had to carry you carry a mortar round. We didn't have any trucks or anything. So they carried the mortar rounds in addition to all the other stuff. They carry these big heavy mortar rounds.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:41
Is there anything you'd like to add about the events of the day?

Ray Albin
35:47
That's a really broad question of Well I mean from the actual attack

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:53
The battle itself.

Ray Albin
35:55
Um one of my everlasting memories is somebody Midway through frantically calling back for a back azimuth, coming over the radio in the gunpit. And this guy was just desperate. So we gave him a back azimuth which is the reverse of your you know y y it's it's just a you know turn around it's a turnaround.

36:16
The azimuth was directly south, the back azimuth is directly north. And the very the very question give us a back azimuth It shows the predicament they were in because I mean there was panic there at that time. Most guys know that if you go out on a on a you know uh three sixty the back azimuth is a one eighty.

36:34
It's just a you know reverse. So that and then after we weren't allowed to fire I got out of the gun hole and I was walking around and I went out to the perimeter and this must have been maybe I have no clue what time. Before twelve, but after 1030.

36:47
And here comes a a American soldier running with nothing on. I mean a pair of pants maybe I guess, but no web gear, helmet, nada.

Clark Welch
36:57
They're not running away. That's the what's what the army teaches you. When you're caught in the kills over an ambush, you run away.

Ray Albin
37:03
And this guy had nothing. And I s then it dawned it dawned on me then it must be horrific there because I'd you know been in Vietnam at that time for five or six months and been through a number of firefights either in the border pit or whatever and I'd never seen that occur. You know so that's like a memory and then go actually going out there and finding Sergeant Barrow there that's

Clark Welch
37:23
That's something that uh when you look at this guy, I I'm uh it's not bull I'm not you don't bullshit anybody anymore. But I was out there because I was told to go out there. I had 150 guys, 142 of us, I had mortars in it.

37:36
That's not bad. You know, you go out there, that's what you're over there for. You're out there to do to fight.

37:42
Now, think of these guys. He's sitting back where he's safe. Uh there's uh there were more people back there where he was than there was with me.

37:51
Many more. Uh he's got more guns than you could possibly carry in ten trucks, he's got plenty of ammunition, he's got water, he's got Medevac helicopters, what do you mean that stuff? And he, he's in the mortar platoon.

38:05
His job is to stay back there. Nobody's nobody's gonna tell him to go forward. His job is to stay back there.

38:12
And he and dozens of other men with him. without orders, because nobody in the goddamn army said, go help Welch or go help nobody until Major Hollander did, and he said, go help them, and they got killed. And that was later.

Ray Albin
38:27
Yes.

Clark Welch
38:28
But somehow he, Tom Hinger, uh I I don't want to get the wrong names. But back there in the in the safety of there, they're in a gun pit. It's a hole in the ground.

38:37
They're perfectly safe. They got ice water The chow trucks probably coming in? Because it uh we were less than a click away, but uh these guys led by Recon, Recon sergeant, because the Recon platoon leader decided not to go, a bunch of sergeants and privates pick up From where they're safe, drinking ice water, and walk into where they know there's just been a total massacre And and they just uh I d I'd like to say that I remember them showing up.

39:14
I don't I remember the the scouts showing up, but I don't really remember that just kind of foggy. But but for these guys, uh It's an amazing I I think about that often what they uh I didn't have any choice. I was out there, I had a choice, I could run away or not run away, and I decided not to run away.

39:32
That's easy But for these guys to be, it's him and the other 20, 25 guys that were within that first burst that came out to get us. Guys who don't have to go out. Their job is to stay back there, which nice and clean, you know, far to the rear.

39:49
And they Yeah, the fighting, a lot of the fighting was over by then, but they were still, as I know now, there were 200 men that worked for Captain Lom, whose job was just to hang around and pick off And I think that's how they got uh Major Hollander. That's how they got Major Hollander.

Ray Albin
40:05
Yeah.

Clark Welch
40:05
The fight was over. But did these guys, him, happen happens to be him. I I I wouldn't know that because I didn't see him, but I believe that he did.

40:16
left, left the safety of the NDP and walked forward. They didn't know how far. You could follow the trail, I guess, a close and stuff, but then But uh it's very reassuring for me to come back with what I remember and have him not say, wait a minute, it wasn't like that at all.

40:42
Because the memory of what happened is so incredibly stupid. Just horrible after horrible after horrible that that couldn't have happened

Ray Albin
40:51

But for me to say, uh, geez, I called and nobody ever shot there was no question that I mean of the people that went there you know out there on the I don't know what you want to call it, it wasn't a rescue mission, but Relief mission or whatever, there was no question of of not going. It's just a question if you were available and you could go. And I mean I was expendable because nobody was going to fire the mortars then anyway, you know.

41:19
I mean why not, you know? And there was guys out there that you know, needed help and if they were going to be evacuated somebody's got to carry them out because triple canopy wouldn't allow for many helicopters to come in and and evacuate 'em. So it was just, you know, kind of like common sense.

41:33
You better get out there as quickly as possible and get as many people back in the case. And call it common sense. It's not common it's not common sense to go walking into something where you know that I was talking about you know the common sense angle of of how do you get people out of triple canopy canopy jungle without having to carry 'em because uh usually you know helicopter those guys would ch set those choppers down anywhere.

41:53
But they they have to have a place And I think we had to make the place with chainsaws and that, and it was a very limited space. So as a result, I think I was telling you yesterday, some guys were left out there overnight that overnight that were dead, you know. And covered with artillery barrage, you know, all night long and that.

42:10
But, you know, that was another thing. So how do we get the guys out? How do we get everybody out, alive or dead?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
42:15
Did you agree with the decision to leave them overnight?

Ray Albin
42:19
I had no part in that decision. I didn't know that anybody was left until I read the book. And if If it would have been, you know, my call, I I I I mean I would have tried, but we tried to carry, I carried out as many guys as we could back to a central Bad word depository, you know, and then as many as could be evacuated by helicopter were, but I wasn't part of the logistics, so It's a written rule.

42:47
Yeah. Yeah. Do not leave anybody behind.

42:49
And in that case it had to be extraordinary that those those Those KIA got left behind.

Clark Welch
42:55
And it it I I I did not know any but one was left behind that day, of course. I'm not sure how I got out. I've had a two well now that the book has been written there's a dozen people claim to have carried me out.

43:07
But I I don't think it's all anyway. I don't know what happened that night. Later on when I find out that the brigade commander ordered them and although that looks fine in a report if you do the kind of stuff that I've spent my life doing in the Army, wait a minute.

43:25
The brigade commander didn't get to 2 o'clock. The sun didn't go down until 8 30. That was a full moon.

43:33
How can he claim that he had to leave them behind because it was too dark? Bullshit. Okay.

43:38
Bullshit Uh that now d does anybody know one of those reports? Did they look it up like I did to find out it's a full moon? Uh kind of a complicated table you have to find to get there.

43:48
And it didn't get dark. Uh When I read later on, uh or you don't read until lately, but when I would see things later on that uh bodies were left behind and then usually parentheses except for the battalion commander who was taken out. What the hell is that?

44:04
When I read that, I just couldn't believe it. And it was one of those things that I'm uh these guys didn't leave anybody behind. No nobody that I know, not in my army, don't leave people behind.

44:15
And when I went over to Vietnam the first time with the man who wrote the book and met Captain Lom. Captain Lom is the man who lived, lives in the same little house that he's lived, his family's lived in for a thousand years. dirt floor, got a concrete floor now because he's very famous because he was in the book.

44:31
He's got electricity, got a little rice cooker, got a TV. Captain Lom's job was to keep he owned that base camp, uh s six kilometers by four kilometers. He owned that.

44:43

And his job was to, when there was nobody around, go up to Cambodia and get rice and bring it down, maintain a doctor place, maintain a dead place. maintainer, sewing machine place, uh weapons. They made all this underground and bunkers left over left behind by the Viet Minh and the French.

45:00

Now when I went to see him, and we were on the battlefield, and I'm talking with Colonel Triet about the battle because Colonel Triet ran the battle, but Captain Lum is with us because he's the guy that was there. He stays there all the time And uh through that conversation, if I told you before, I don't, but through when Captain Lam stopped and looked at me in some English, some Vietnamese. But my Vietnamese came back enough so it was just like we were good old friends talking.

45:26

And he put his hand in my chest and he said, he Colonel, they were very correct. They called me Colonel Welch. I called him Colonel Triet, Captain Lam No doubt about it.

45:35

A not my friend, friend's not the right word, but my warrior comrade or something. We're we're we're friends. And uh little Captain Lobb, little tiny guy, pokes me in the chest.

45:47

You're not a very good soldier, Colonel Weltson. And that's not a good thing to say to me. That's uh just a you can't I can't think of anything to say to me any words.

45:55

You're not a good soldier And I said, what are you talking about? I thought maybe I misunderstood. He said, you left your dead here.

46:01

Now, when Captain Lum says that, yeah, Captain Lum. Now his job is to, after the battle's over, he goes around the battlefield, he ignores the Americans, doesn't bury them, doesn't do anything with them, doesn't want to touch them. They're like space aliens.

46:16

Captain Alam goes around, picks up the wounded guys, brings them to the doctor place, the dead guys bring them to the dead place, sends the numbers back. That's his job. When he said to me, you're not a good soldier, you left your dead here And I it really made me mad.

46:31

And I want to say, hey, don't blame me. I was uh, and I I did you don't say don't blame me, but that was what I want to say. And and it's but I just yes we did.

46:43

We did. He said you left them here for five days. Now I had read the reports that said it was only overnight.

46:50
Now what Captain Lung told me that he every day of his life he gets out walks around. Sometimes there's Americans there, sometimes there's not. He walks around.

46:58
He had to walk about a half mile to go to a good well that was the far end of that draw. And that uh that night while he came out on the battlefield to recover his own dead and wounded, because Colonel Triet left at 12 o'clock. When Captain Lom came out that night, he found what he called a stack of bodies.

47:19
He said they were right there. And he said they were like firewood. This is what he's telling me just four years ago.

47:25
And I well We shouldn't have left him there. Very bad soldier, very bad soldier. And stayed out here for five days.

47:33
And I said, oh, five days. I thought Everybody came out the next day. And he said most of them were recovered the next day at as soon as it got light.

47:42
Most of them were recovered. But I'll take you to where there was a body and it stayed there for five days. And then David Moranis was hoping that that would be the body of one of our MIA, because we uh we, I say we, it was Alpha Company, but it's all the world together.

48:00
We have we still have two MIA. And I went back to Vietnam in 73 to look for MIA.

Ray Albin
48:07
That was Hargrove and Fitzgerald.

Clark Welch
48:08
Hargrove and Fitzgerald, two tall black guys. that I saw running away as they should, two tall black guys running through the woods with with no shirts. run on the wrong direction.

48:21
They ran that way and what you should have done was come back to me or gone that way, but it they went the right. But anyway, uh David Moratus was talking he's writing a book he says

this will be cool you know technique maybe we can find the missing in action and uh we went back to it it made me think that Captain Lom was telling the truth because he said it's right over here that where the battlefield is has all been made over into rubber. The Russians did that in their five-year plan.

48:47
And that rubber grew up and then this is the second crop of rubber. So everything's different. But we walked over to a place on the other side of the drawer and he said that big tree, and you could still see the hulk of a big tree, he was right at the bottom of that big tree.

49:00
It kind of gross I wouldn't want You know, once you quote it, the uh he said the pigs come out and eat on him at night. I don't know if that's true or not. That may be just a Vietnamese phrase.

49:15
He said he'd been all blown up like a bomb. I don't know. Now David Moranis wanted it to be somebody, and he was trying to angle it so he'd be able to get, and David Moranis is my dear friend.

49:29
I'm not saying he's doing anything wrong, but his job is to write a book. and he wants to find out something neat about this. So we go back there and he starts to talk to the guy about, you know, how big it was and I said, I said to Captain Lum, uh this man you found here.

49:42
Did he have uh white skin or black skin? And the Vietnamese are very aware they don't like black people, they don't like Cambodians, they don't like Koreans, they don't they're very uh uh what I don't know, nationalistic or something. And he and he uh I said to the you know white skin and black skin.

49:59
He said, no black, no black, white, white, white, like you So that disappointed David Randis. That disappointed David Randis that it wasn't the uh missing guy. But the point is, incredibly The United States Army decided to leave 25, 35 bodies there, stacked like firewood.

50:20
And they they claim that they fired artillery on them all night. Well, artillery is no good unless you get somebody there to watch it. 'Cause I don't know how it happens, but the guns barrels droop a little bit, so you shoot, boom.

50:33
Next time you shoot goes there, boom. Now, if you look on the Vietnam Wall All, or almost all, of our dead from that day died of shrapnel wounds. Now I believe that during the night our

artillery hit some of our dead men.

Ray Albin
50:58
And I think I told you uh yesterday, Carrie, that according to the book, that was something that bothered me that that The next day they went out and they found several that weren't stacked, and two of that several had no rigor mortise set in at that point. And I mentioned that to Joe Devine And he said, get over it. But that's And and that's nobody's fault.

51:27
I mean we just didn't the guys didn't find everybody that was wounded because people were, you know, moving about. And I one of my foremost memories is about two years ago I got a an email from a the sister of an un I'm not going to mention the the guy's name because he was killed, but the sister writing on behalf of of one of the men in in in our company that was killed. And this is thirty-five years later, thirty-four years later, and this sister was writing on to me on behalf of the mother wanting to know if the son had been evacuated.

51:58
that day or that that day or had he laid on the battlefield overnight and I said to the best of my recollection he had been evacuated and I didn't know that but I mean as long as this is, you know that was the best way to handle it. Because here's a mother thirty-five years later wanting to know if her deceased son had been evacuated or not. And for the all for her best interest.

52:25
I mean I didn't tell the truth there. I didn't lie, but I didn't know, so I said, absolutely. You know I remember because I did carry him out.

52:32
I had carried him out.

Clark Welch
52:33
It's just hard to comprehend out.

Ray Albin
52:34
I had carried him out and and you know, two men to a stretcher to carry out one guy With a little extra effort, we could have carried out a lot of those guys that were stacked. You know, I I believe. But maybe, you know, again, I'm on the low end of the of the of the f uh the food chain so to speak.

Clark Welch
52:50
Maybe there was overriding circumstances and I always want to believe the best of the kind of

kind of you know I'm kinda tired of trying to believe I can't figure out any reason. I've met Colonel Newman a couple of times Colonel Lehman doesn't come to many of these events. He may be dead now.

53:04
I've seen him once since then. And he uh I I sat at a table with him and my I went, sir, why'd you leave the guys? I wanted to ask him, but uh I I was able to stop that.

53:15
I do not know that he left my guys. What I know is, and we were all still there, uh when when I passed out or went out or it's uh yeah we left them behind incredible we should have brought the United States Army in and But it it was only a click away.

Ray Albin
53:36
Yeah.

Clark Welch
53:37
Uh full moon.

Ray Albin
53:40
So I want to believe that there was there was something that I didn't know that was a bigger book. That's the way I deal with it. I'm about out of the stats. I don't mean to laugh about that, but I mean I guess you know.

Clark Welch
53:55
Uh you have us some better questions.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
53:57
Okay.

Clark Welch
53:59
How about when Miss South Carolina came to visit your problem?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
54:02
Well that one was that one was very broad. Um well you s I think you may have sort of answered it, but let me zero in on it. Um do you place any blame on the battle d on anybody. I mean Newman, um Coleman, I mean I don't I mean just leadership. I mean do you is is there anyone hey I mean Even in your own mind?

Clark Welch

54:30

I uh the Army has something called uh that they formalize very much and I was in on it and uh called an after action review. That after something happens, you go around the table and say, what'd you do right? What'd you do wrong?

54:42

And what are you gonna do to make sure you never do it again? Now you call that finding blame. I have done that for that was my my work in life, everything you do.

54:52

It's very difficult not to do it now. My wife kind of gets pissed off when, you know, everything we do, we Well, Lacey, how'd that go? And I'm kind of serious about it.

54:59

You know, should we pack more food next time? Should we not bear next pair of jackets? So I spent my whole life doing that.

55:06

Uh started doing that while it was going on I do hold people responsible because I'm in the army that taught me when I was in high school, dreaming about being a soldier someday, getting a little books that a commander or leader is responsible for everything a unit does or fails to do. They don't teach that now. You know, one of the one of the Ways to lead now is by avoidance.

55:32

That's a, you know, just make sure you don't ever get blamed for anything. Well, I do hold leaders responsible. Uh I hold myself responsible.

55:41

I'm doing better at that now than I did for thirty years. But I I am responsible. Now uh I fought about as good as I could on the 17th, but somehow I couldn't find the words on the evening of the sixteenth.

55:52

to somehow make a difference. Carrie? So I am responsible.

55:56

And my boss is responsible, the colonel. I am not I don't have deadly thoughts about him because I've met his daughters, his orphans, who are dear friends of mine. Colonel Newman is responsible.

56:11

The other brigade commander who transferred our battalion from one brigade to the other and

forgot to tell anybody about it and forgot to find out that oops, I could better tell the new brigade commander that The battalion commander that you're getting just came back from a month trying to fix his wedding or marriage. So I blame those two brigade commanders. And I blame our commanding general.

56:35
And I blame the guy that was in charge and I blame the President of the United States for things that occurred. I hold those people responsible. I am doing much better and not uh wanting to throttle anybody.

56:49
I hold the major responsible. I came out and uh what Lieutenant Mager told me was he's got a gun or something like that. He's got a gun.

56:58
I can't shoot, he's got a gun I hold him responsible. As I work my way up, I like to do what he's able to do, that there must be something going on up there that But I can't find anything.

Ray Albin
57:13
I think Clark's being a little tough on himself here. Okay. I mean I I I'm not privy to any of this firsthand but I I am privy to this.

57:26
Subsequent to the 17th, there was never a word that I heard from any of the survivors. And there weren't many, of course. And in the mortar platoon, we survived because, you know.

57:35
But anybody say, well, Welch really screwed us up. That never ever was uttered. I lived 30 years thinking and I didn't know that, you know, and geez if I'd have known he was going through all that.

57:48
You know, which I had no way of knowing, I had to try to contact him or you know, or something to tell him. But but the point was nobody ever blamed Lieutenant Welch. Okay, so therefore Lieutenant Welch must have been following suborders because I gotta tell you, most of us would have trusted Lieutenant Welch's instinct rather than anybody Colonel Alder, anybody's military expertise gained at West Point or wherever, and nothing to denigrate West Point, but the instinct that Lieutenant Welch had was proven and you know over the months that we had known him.

58:21
And then when I read the book and Lieutenant Welch approaches Colonel Allen as much as you can approach a colonel when you're a lieutenant and say, um, we're not going back in the same

way we did yesterday, are we, sir? And it's a matter of no discussion, then you're subsequently gonna follow orders and you're gonna do what you're told, knowing that you're probably gonna be in some deep trouble, which is why then he comes around the night before and tells us, you know, big uh big trouble tomorrow and tells everybody, which I never heard a company commander tell before. pack all the ammo you could carry.

58:57
I've never heard anybody say that, okay, before or after that. And didn't say anything about water and stuff, because I guess it goes unsaid. But I mean that that was like a I mean there's certain messages that you can give without saying that we're in deep duty, and that was one of them, you know.

Clark Welch
59:13
And uh And I w I wouldn't have said it was a screwed up operation. I know my first sergeant just talked to me about that after that that you know. I'm not a I don't mean that I'm a hero that I've made we you somewhere it's gotta stop.

59:27
You can't you can't come back to the guys and say, look guys We're all going to get killed tomorrow. This is screwed up things I'd ever heard of. Right.

59:33
No, but just So you take a deep breath and you say, uh bring lots of ammo. Yeah, prepare yourself. That everybody knows.

Ray Albin
59:38
Yeah. Yeah.

Clark Welch
59:40
We even knew where.

Ray Albin
59:41
But when they say lots of, you know, guys already brought enough. You know what I mean? So when they're saying lots of, there's a there's a message there.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
59:49
Read between the lines.

Ray Albin
59:50

Yeah, exactly. You know, without saying, hey, you know, it's we're not gonna do well tomorrow.

Clark Welch
59:53
You know, we had lots of mortar ammunition because we had pretty well expended everything we had on hand on the sixteenth. I'm not sure how they did it because that's their business But I know that we had a full everything was full up again on the 17th.

Ray Albin
01:00:07
Yeah, so I mean and again I'm not privy to what Lieutenant you know, Colonel Welch was privy to, but I do know that, you know, if he would have said we're gonna go there, we would have you know, we'd have done that. And he did say go there, but he was somebody else was pushing his button so to speak. Which is that's the military, you know.

Clark Welch
01:00:26
It wasn't like pressure, it was just just what you do.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:00:31
Um skip ahead just a bit

Clark Welch
01:00:35
You're just spending too much time talking curiously. We will have schedule.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:00:40
We need to be quiet.

Clark Welch
01:00:42
We may learn something here.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:00:48
Okay, I'm gonna skip that just a little bit. How do you feel about some of the works that have been written about the battle? Moranus's book, uh Jim Shelton's book. Some of the other things. How do you the PBS DVD that was completed?

Clark Welch
01:01:06
Do you think they're the quick answer? I I've I've not read about Wisconsin. I don't care about Wisconsin.

01:01:14
Except that I flipped through when I went up to Wisconsin for the grand opening of the movie and I knew I was going to be on some boards. I flipped through it, looked in the index for the names, so I know who the people were I was going to be talking with I don't care anything about that. But the uh the Vietnam part of the book was was accurate.

01:01:31
Uh in most cases David Moranis doesn't say this is what Clark told me what he did. This is what uh uh uh Ray told me in most cases he says Joe and Jim and Slim say that Ray did this or these four guys saw Welch do this. Uh It's it's very accurate.

01:01:50
And it is uh sympathetic, not the right word, but I think it's he a Washington Post reporter who's not like us For him to write, he didn't even know what soldiers were. And at the end of it, he said, I'm never gonna write a book like that again. I can't do it.

01:02:05
He said there's a thousand stories here But I'll never I can never do this again. It's just too much. Uh he is an a he changed our lives.

01:02:14
We were we were killing ourselves by suicide at a weight of about one every ten years Uh yes, some of the guys. And uh one of the guys tried to commit suicide and has uh with a forty-five in the face, so it's no kidding. Serious, not not slash your wrists or anything.

01:02:31
And he survived and he tells me Four times a year. He lives in the mountains of Tennessee, that I'll never do that again. That because of the book and because he now has a better understanding.

01:02:44
So what David Moranis did is uh wonderful. He's an angel. Whenever I get a chance to see anybody, but I say David Morandis changed our life.

01:02:52
And that's true. That's true. And and David will, if he's there, we always say, no, no, no. You know, Clark and his guys changed my life.

01:02:58
I didn't know anything about these kind of people. His book was excellent. Uh Steve Bowman's book is excellent.

01:03:05
Steve Bowman's book, now my understanding, you of course know absolutely the details, was I

guess, was getting ready to be published and somebody noticed that oops she left out the battle a long time or something like that. But what Steve Bowman did put in there eventually was very good. If you're just flipping through the stars and stripes, you go right by the Battle of Enton.

01:03:25
You know, colonel died, but hell, colonels die all the time. They they put big buildings up for them and then everything's even and it's all straightened up. But the uh now and there have been some other articles That I've read over the years.

01:03:38
My my son just sent me one that was in VFW magazine a couple weeks ago, months ago. It irks me a little bit that there are errors. But it just it just clarifies for me that what I read in today's newspaper seems to be bullshit.

01:03:54
Well, as a matter of fact, what I can read in the papers when I know For thirty years I didn't know if I knew what I knew. You know, I thought I knew it, but hell, I couldn't get it. That yeah, it it irks me that there are inaccuracies, but nothing uh bothers except that movie, the PBS movie.

01:04:15
That uh was made, they did not, my understanding of it was, and I fully cooperated with them and told all my soldiers. I don't know if you went, right?

Ray Albin
01:04:23
I did, yeah. I did I was I was interviewed on the phone, but I didn't do a uh a A visual, you know, a recorded interview.

Clark Welch
01:04:28
But David Morana said we could trust him. It was represented to me that PBS out of Boston was going to do it. I called a man PBS in Boston and he's a good man, patriot.

01:04:39
He's the president of PBS or something. I feel The front we still correspond. Yeah, gonna make a movie about it?

01:04:45
Good. Okay. I think I'll tell my guys it's alright to participate And they theoretically, what he told me, they've hired a producer, director in Wash in uh Hollywood called uh Rob Kenner, whose wife acts as his assistant.

01:05:00

And would we work together with him? Yeah. No mention that the script for that one-hour program was written by a University of Wisconsin writer.

01:05:11

Now, how do you write a documentary? How do you make sure that you get a soldier at one time, say, the end of that movie where they get the uh uh machine gunner uh uh sister How do you get her he wrote ahead of time. Now I don't know this for fact, but He's the writer.

01:05:35

How do you write a documentary? Well, as a matter of fact, you write so that the questions you ask will make her say, I wasn't sure who was right or wrong. That's not fair.

01:05:45

It's not right. Of course we said all those things. I was interviewed for eight hours.

01:05:49

He says long interview we'd ever hit. And and they they pick out 20 seconds of what I said. Well, how about the stuff I said about these guys?

01:05:58

So that that DVD uh uh PBS show was made under false pretenses. They should have leveled with us that it's being funded by the University of Wisconsin. Wisconsin PBS is the real sponsor, not Boston PBS.

01:06:15

It's a that that's a very poor, poor piece of work. And I'm sorry that I you know they they they called us and offered to come on out and we'll put you up in a, I'd never heard the phrase before, boutique hotel in uh Hollywood or something. You know, it's just quite whether pick you up in a limousine uh and my guys would call back after the interview and say it went all right.

01:06:40

So we do okay, another guy can go, another guy can go. And then to see that uh uh piece of work that they came out with and it won a lot of awards. He calls me to ask me, still didn't ask me anymore because I'm not gonna go, but you know, please come with us to the Peabody or the Peabody is that an award?

Ray Albin

01:06:58

Yeah.

Clark Welch

01:06:58

He got a Peabody Award, he got something else. Emmy?

Ray Albin

01:07:00
He got an Emmy for uh Emmy and a Peabody, I think. Last year, I think, yeah.

Clark Welch
01:07:04
So would you come? No. I I really feel betrayed by that. And I'm nervous about the movie that Hollywood may be going to make.

01:07:15
Uh I don't want my guys remembered like that. I I cried when she uh Sikorsky's sister, who's now named something else was sitting next to me when that movie was reviewed in Wisconsin. Just I saw her at the back.

01:07:29
She's a very pretty woman, but I I I memorized this guy. I don't remember the names, but I know these guys And she was sitting in waiting back, so I waited for her to come down, and she came down the front row and she and her husband, and uh there wasn't enough room there. So I yelled down the road because some civilian people in the University of Wisconsin I didn't like very much by that time.

01:07:49
Said move down, got somebody gonna sit here. So she and her husband sat next to me and we watched the whole movie. And they'd show a little bit of movie and then they'd call us up on the stage to be on a panel and they'd ask you know, some history professor with two doctorates would ask me a question.

01:08:05
Well I'm not a you know, that's not a fair fight. It's not a I mean I don't mind being asked things, but he's got this real sophisticated question and bullshit. Uh So it wasn't a very pleasant thing.

01:08:17
And then when we saw the end of that movie and the it the the TV show ends with her saying, I don't know who was right and who was wrong. Well, that ain't right. Her brother was right We're not talking about the President of the United States.

01:08:29
We're talking about and they made her say that by I'm not accusing you of doing that, but the the he the guy was in a wheelchair, the writer. He didn't introduce himself as being from the University of Wisconsin, he just said, I'm I'm helping out her. The last question they asked during my interview with them after eight hours with the lights and was uh if you had been at the University of Wisconsin, eighteen years old, your father, mother voted Democratic for 18 years, this, this, and this You were, you know, you thought this was terrible.

01:08:57

And the final part of the question was, uh, uh, and your girlfriend have just been beaten up by the police? Do you think you would have participated in that the events at Wisconsin? And uh excuse my language, but the uh Eileen Forrest at the stupidest fucking question I've ever heard.

01:09:16
This interview is over And then I got to thinking, man, is that the kind of thing that they've been asking my guys? What's the answer to that? The answer is sure I would.

01:09:24
I would have killed a policeman if he beat up my girlfriend. Uh I fortunately I didn't say that. I don't know what he asked you on the phone, but the uh I really felt betrayed by that.

01:09:35
And it uh it has caused some divisions in our uh group uh that's uh that's terrible. The book didn't do that. The book was yeah almost without exception the book I know I've said more than I should uh It's it's always it's always uh 40 years too late.

01:09:59
You know, 40 years too late.

Ray Albin
01:10:02
David Maranus's book, Maranus? Yeah, there's a way to pronounce it I always forget. in 2003 in October, just after the book was released, and did a question and answer thing.

01:10:19
And I I was there and I met him and I I talked to the guy on the phone and did emails with him, but I never met him. just the nicest guy and I at the very end I I felt I mean I didn't want to I didn't tell anybody I was part of that or anything I just stood up and said that from my perspective when the when David wrote the book he had no agenda He was writing a a history, you know, a multifaceted history, and I trusted him completely. After I talked to him for about 10 minutes on the phone, I could get a read on him.

01:10:50
He was just, uh I have nothing good things to say about him and the book, and that's the way I feel now. The only thing that I regret is that both in well, in in the book, uh I mean and and David Merinus and I get along very well and everything, and I I don't have any I mean, he wrote the book, it's his book. But I think from my perspective that Pinky Durham could have gotten more.

Clark Welch
01:11:16
That's that's a funny disconnect in there. I don't understand how he could have had more I mean here's a guy that wins a congressional.

Ray Albin
01:11:22
We certainly said enough about him. Yeah, he he wins a congressional medal of honor. Maybe because he wasn't a black lion, but who cares?

01:11:28
He was he was with us and he was defending himself and us. So that and then of course You turn to uh Two Days in October by Robbie Kenner and I've I've contacted him and you know talked to him. Um that was his piece, obviously, but there's not a mention In that 90 minute documentary of the year.

01:11:48
Very powerful documentary, but very powerful, but not mentioning Pinky Durham at all.

Clark Welch
01:11:53
Durham's family is not here now, and they would have been last year, last year, last year. Pinky Durham's brother who was in the army And Pinky Durham s sister. Uh Pinky wasn't married. Pinky had a bunch of girlfriends we found.

Ray Albin
01:12:06
But I don't know why the You know, it's it it the the the film sound like that we were I mean, at least when I watched it, I watched it several times. It it seemed to me like they portrayed Delta and Alpha Company as victims. you know, uh rather as defenseless victims I got the feeling, you know, that we did it and we just stood there and took fire, you know. But I mean I'm telling you that there were There were countless acts that day that'll go un you know I mean un untold because nobody survived. But if you watch the film, you would say that we never maybe squeezed off around

Clark Welch
01:12:46
Well some of the guys said that. And that was the quote they picked out to use, you know, that I didn't shoot very much.

Ray Albin
01:12:52
But damn. I mean, I've always said that I think in that thing that uncommon valor was common that day. And I'll go to my grave thinking that, but it'll be unreported for the most part because There's only a handful of guys that lived in the middle.

Clark Welch
01:13:07
You know that the uh movie They Were Soldiers Once in Young. That battalion commander

survived and went on to be a four-star general. That man that was we had a news we had a photographer with us named Gilbert.

01:13:23
He was killed right away. Who was killed? Well, the photographer that was with the we were soldiers once in young grew up to write a Pillitzer Prize and be a famous guy.

01:13:34
And I I would I don't say I won't give anything, it's too late to say, but my guys deserve that Two of our guys have been disinterred because when their bodies were sent home, the bodies were just sent home. He died. They didn't have wives, didn't have families, they had mothers.

01:13:51
They all had mothers And uh, but now we're in touch with the people. And uh I wish you could have been there the day that uh chiseling Tizial. Tizio radio operator, that his his little sister met my two radio operators because they knew Tizio, radio, two both named Scott.

01:14:15
And uh I saw the three of them talking over there and they're crying and I went over to of course everybody's crying. The get together in Las Vegas is different from here. Yeah, yeah, it's it's uh it's a hard it's uh but I say what's can I help?

01:14:33
What's the matter? And and she said, and my two guys, two Scots, Scott up and Scott down, are saying that uh they just told her That Tizio said, if I die, and I'm not going to die, none of us are going to die, but Tizio had told them, and they were relating to his sister, that if I die, I want to be buried at Arlington. And none of our guys are buried at Arlington.

01:14:55
Because the guys who die, they just get sent home. No no no bronze star, no purple heart even. So in in her case So sitting at that table, we agreed that we would do what we could to get him buried in Arlington where he told his buddies he wanted to be.

01:15:12
And then I wrote a couple letters and I finally got a letter back from somebody that said Uh uh y you can only be reinterred in Arlington if you get a note from the President of the United States, some general. And I wrote a letter back to that general saying, Well you damn fool? Call the President of the United States And General Shelton got me quieter down to write a letter correctly.

01:15:33
And we got the note. It doesn't have to be signed by the president anymore, but we got the note signed by the president. And he was dug up from this little family plot in New downtown New York City.

01:15:43
And we re-interred him, I've learned there's the name And we had uh David Moranis was there. Twenty guys were there. Ed Burke was there with a uh have you seen picture of this?

01:15:53
He well he was reinterred there. Now, that's why I say it's 35 years too late You know, when these guys came home, when Pinky Durham came home, his father went crazy. His mother died a couple months later.

01:16:05
Father died a couple years later. Uh Pinky Durham came home without the metal bottom. He just came home dead.

01:16:11
It was a year or so later before the uh I don't think his mother and father were still alive when they presented Pinky the metal bone. Uh this guy Tusio came home. His mother and father died within a couple of months.

01:16:25
So it's it's 35, 40 years too late, but it's uh It's been very good. Your last chapter. Things are so much better.

01:16:39
They can't be made right. And you see

Ray Albin
01:16:45
The good thing is for me that's in the public domain now. Yeah. You know, and for all those years I never, there was no need to talk about it because You know, like I told you yesterday, how do you go up and say, oh I was in this battle and we got a lot of guys killed?

01:16:57
I mean that just doesn't work, you know. So now that it's in the public domain, if people ask, you can tell them. But even if they don't ask, people can read about it in the book And they can understand.

01:17:14
It's very powerful. Yeah, if it's powerful Somebody thought it was good and it created it it it it caused people that we don't even know about, you know, to talk. And yeah, in some way it f it makes me feel that those guys got there justice because they didn't die unknown like so many other there's there's a hundred of those battles in Vietnam.

01:17:32
I mean there's you know I mean not maybe with the intensity and not with all the political

juxtaposition and the president here and Wisconsin here. There's that's just one day of three sixty five that every soldier served in Vietnam, particularly infantry guys. And now that is out there for people to either read or see or evaluate and that's a good thing to me.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:17:54
It seems like those publications, the reunions, it seems like it's It's therapeutic.

Clark Welch
01:17:59
Yeah, I i it is. I I don't I don't understand therapeutic and that other word closure or something. People you have closure?

01:18:04
I don't know. But the uh the the thing that uh you don't celebrate a losing season. I see these, I really envy these World War II veterans.

01:18:13
Who can show you, whether you see the maps, you can buy a map. You don't want to see a map of what I did in Vietnam. Went over here, went over here, finally got shot here, got the hospital, came back, went around, got shot, came back, finally went out, went to Japan.

01:18:24
What the hell kind of a map is that? Well these these world I really envy these world wars. I wish I was, you know, born back in the twenty or something.

01:18:32
That the uh uh Iraq is doing, I don't want to say Iraq, doing the same thing, where they had such a clear-cut thing and they won. You don't celebrate a losing season. No And now it's a losing season, yeah, but that's not what we talk about.

01:18:49
We were winning. When we left, we were winning. that the the enemy colonel said, why'd you leave?

01:18:55
Yeah. Well we were uh you know Tet uh in that battle he lost some people, he lost so many people. He didn't lose as many as the report said, 120 or something.

01:19:04
But he said he lost a company. That would be 60 or 80 pounds. But for him to lose a company, that meant that he, what he was supposed to do was pass through, link up with the rest of the division, and lead the division in tech.

01:19:17

Because he was delayed and lost so many people, and because his division commander was pissed off at him for getting in a fight, this is what he tells me, when he came up there to get ready for Tet, he arrived too late and understrength, so he was third in line instead of first in line when they attacked Saigon. And he said to me, Colonel Welch, you saved my life. I would have been killed.

01:19:37
And and why did you guys leave in Tet? You know, t you won in Tet. We didn't have anybody left.

01:19:44
So we we can feel comfortable that uh it uh we're winning when we left. And I don't know what justification that is, but that uh it's not so it's not You just talked too much, Kerry. Well, I I'd still like to ask one question unless you've got uh Well I've got about 18 more questions, but go ahead. Go ahead. Sure.

01:20:25
I interviewed a artillery observer earlier in the this reunion. This is Andrew Woods from 1st Division Museum. And he had said, uh, you know, he was in one of the bird dog planes.

01:20:38
And and he had said most battles he would direct artillery to fire on enemy troops But in this case they told him not to direct artillery on it. So so to me that says this is this is coming from higher up than the than the major than the major that's with the mortar platoon. And and it was his idea that this was some sort of West Point doctrine not to use artillery in this situation. The artillery that day was very strange because the enemy was uh three meters away. You know, the guys I was shooting at when things first started, they were shooting at us from the tree. And the trees are uh three feet away.

01:21:27
I I sh I don't want to talk about me. I sh uh the first guy I shot with my forty five was right up there. And when I shot him, uh the blood from him came down and landed on my first side.

01:21:36
He said, What the hell are you doing? I said, Well I shot that guy. And he fell out of the tree.

01:21:41
So th they were You know, you can't fire artillery at a band that's right there like the Zealand. And you can't fire artillery at the and when I went, I I felt that they were too close. I knew about the mortars because you can see a mortar round come through the trees, who boom, and then you can say, okay, I want to bring that ten feet closer, you know, two meters, go right two meters, or whatever my stuff would be.

01:22:04

And with the artillery, we fired large artillery, was fired far away, 1155s. We had some of those because I could hear them. The ones I cared about were the 105s, which are really about to see. He's got 81 105s you can see a 105 come through the tree.

01:22:18
And Pinky Durham would be the one who'd say, okay, I got that one. Move it two meters closer. Move it five meters closer.

01:22:25
Man, that's a. But now what artillery wants to do is shoot and you know adjust 500 meters. Drop 500. Well no, drop 500 wouldn't have done me any good.

01:22:37
So the The artillery, uh, I wanted it to fire all the time. And there's supposed to be some other mad magician up there that his stuff fires like that. Artillery fires like that, airplanes go like that, helicopters go like that.

01:22:51
Well you goddamn well ought to figure it out. Some son of a bitch up there should have been doing his job like we were doing ours. Instead of having somebody came come along and say, hey, this is too complicated, let's stop everything. Durham was calling in? It was two or three batteries, I believe. Okay. Now I never cared. What I cared about was I've got one radio.

01:23:16
I've got a radio that goes to him and I got another radio goes to the artillery. And whether five, six, eight, or ten was shooting for me really didn't make any difference, except that I knew all of our artillery was coming from uh all of our mortars were coming from behind us, so prepare to shoot them on the left and right. And all of artillery was coming from directly to the uh east.

01:23:37
So when the artillery, because the artillery does the same thing. Sometimes it's long, sometimes it's short, but it very seldom is off that way. So you fire the artillery in front of you and behind you, like we'd done on the set 16th.

01:23:49
It was really very, very simple. Now when it didn't work was just, I mean the plan was uh I mean the plan it's not that we did it on paper and didn't it it it should we should have done it like we did it on the 16th

Ray Albin
01:24:02
And the North Vietnamese weren't stupid. I mean if if if I'm a North Vietnamese and you have a preponderance of artillery, my only chance is to move closer to you. to negate the the the amount of artillery you could bring in on me.

Clark Welch
01:24:15
He said grab you by the belt buckle. Yeah oh that's what the phraseology I didn't have a belt buckle but he grabbed the front of my shirt said grab you by the belt buckle. And they did they were right there. And and uh when I would hear the colonel airstrikes, you know, gonna bring in some air. God damn, sir, what are you talking about Uh yeah, air is even further than artillery would be. A mile away. And and our enemy is uh ten feet away. So it's the mortal. It's the mortars you really needed.

Ray Albin
01:24:46
And there's a just something I I recall about the mortars too. A lot of times we had fired mortars. This was triple canopy

Clark Welch
01:24:52
It was, it was really, I've heard you get true. I just read one of the new things over there that talked about uh fairly open jungle. No, it was as solid as could be. It took us uh two hours to go uh thousand meters.

Ray Albin
01:25:04
Yeah, there's a chance that waters are fired into that kind of tur or that kind of foliage that you get tree burst. In other words, the round would explode in the trees because it thinks it thinks it has impacted on the ground. So it's going to explode at the first solid contact.

01:25:19
So then you have a a shrapnel spread that's you know all encompassing. But again, at that point, if your guys are getting overrun and they're you know in the monster wounded and stuff. Does it really, you know, it is it is it a negative to fire your own work, you know, sir?

Clark Welch
01:25:35
As part of the uh when I met the enemy commander and we uh we stood there and I said, I think I was here. Looks different, but I I knew where we were I think we're here. And Colonel Triad looked at me and says, Colonel Welch, you were right here.

01:25:48
And I said, good, and I understand. And I said, Colonel Triad, where were you? He said, over there.

01:25:56
And I said, how far? He said about 60 meters. 60?

01:26:00

60. 6-0.

Ray Albin
01:26:01
And that was his command?

Clark Welch
01:26:02
No, that was him saying that's where it now. And then Captain Lam says, I know where you were. Because the bunker, the command bunker, is still there.

01:26:09
It's not a bunker anymore, it's just where the dirt has sagged in because the big tractors go back and forth on it. So then when David Moranis read his stupid poem written by the Colonel's widow stupid poem written by the Colonel's widow that he read, even though we now know because we've seen the film that the Colonel's widow kind of had something to do with all this. The uh uh Colonel Triette said, I will leave you Americans alone while you do this.

01:26:34
I will measure the distance. So he takes off. 62 meters between me and the enemy regimental commander.

01:26:44
Unheard of. It's impossible. Yeah.

01:26:48
62 meters. I mean there's 62 meters out here in the hallway. So regimental commanders there.

01:26:54
I'm here. 62 meters So you're on top of him, but he's got a regiment and you've got a He's been digging in for five days. There's two battalions on the right, one battalion on the left. We're here. He's there. This battalion on the left was uh uh as he told me after a couple minutes I saw that you guys weren't gonna move so I ordered them to and he stands up like this I ordered him to move in on you So the uh and then we said on that day all 1400 of us fired at the Americans.

Ray Albin
01:27:27
And that under that's two under-strength companies.

Clark Welch
01:27:33
Do you think it would be correct to say that you surprised each other? No. No, no. uh stuff about what happened in you know why would they let you in that close uh uh what colonel triet told me uh is they just wanted us to go. He said, I prayed to my God that you would turn

around. And you did not turn around.

01:27:58
You kept coming, you kept coming, you kept coming. I I know that's what I said. We're where he and I are standing there.

01:28:04
Davorance is creeping in trying to write down stuff. And we can tell him to leave us alone. Said, you kept coming.

01:28:10
And then uh he said, I prayed to God, I prayed to my God that uh that you would turn around. But you kept coming, you kept coming, you kept coming. And finally I had to knock the two sticks together, which is in the book.

01:28:24
David Moratis made me promise that I wouldn't, because that we were on the ground and he heard that, so he wrote down, knock two sticks together, that's cool. And he made me promise afterwards not to ever tell anybody that the battle started by knocking two sticks together because that would be in his book. And that and anyway.

01:28:40
Now you can't. Yeah, now I can. But he said it. He said it.

01:28:43
He said uh I prayed to God that you turn around. All we wanted was food. We had to uh uh we were taking leaves off the trees, taking grass off the ground.

01:28:53
He said uh, I said, Colonel Triet, you're you had tough soldiers. He said, Colonel Welch, all soldiers are tough

Ray Albin
01:29:00
Andrew, they did cracking us since they left the NDP at 8 o'clock. I bet you the the the movement of our guys at 8 o'clock, probably they they were aware of it 801.

Clark Welch
01:29:09
Yeah. Sure yeah. Sure just another day for them.

Ray Albin
01:29:11
Yeah, yeah.

Clark Welch

01:29:12
They well they they were ever they were.

Ray Albin
01:29:13
Because the Americans were there on the sixteenth and we're not leaving. You know, they knew we were staying there. They didn't see any helicopters coming in to evacuate us or to take us out. They knew the operation was still ongoing

Clark Welch
01:29:22
So they were they they were fully used so we could get the rice. Well, and you were going out there to find a main force, too. Yep.

Ray Albin
01:29:32
In contrary of Clark or Lieutenant Welsh's best instincts.

Clark Welch
01:29:37
We found him. Well, I think we're thank you very much. Thank you for your time. Yeah. You got a decompression room here. Thank you. Carrie, I'll I'll answer the rest of your questions.

Ray Albin
01:29:57
I will too. This will probably be the one and only time. I know.